however, stopped him from joining and insisted that he help in the factory. Parkash's elder brother, Manohar, had done his Bachelor of Commerce and would have been the right person to go there, but he did not get along very well with his father and, therefore, the more dutiful and obedient younger son was made to give up college.

Parkash was a sensitive young man who was disturbed by the way in which women had to play a subservient role in society and had virtually no rights or privileges. He thus decided not to marry as, in a joint family structure like his, his wife's lot would be no better than that of the other women in the household. His widowed aunt (his father's sister) always stayed with them and his father always acceded to her wishes in the manner of a kind brother helping an unfortunate sister. She had talked to, and arranged with, a well-known and respectable family of Amritsar for the hand of their daughter for Parkash. When he refused to budge from his stand of not getting married, she gave up eating food altogether. He was, therefore, compelled to accede to her wishes.

At the age of twenty, on 18 February 1942, Parkash Lal married Janak, daughter of Lala Bishan Dass Arora, who belonged to a spiritual and a wealthy family of Amritsar, which provided regular charity lunches to the poor and the needy. At the very tender age of fourteen, Janak, who later changed her name to Prem Lata, had the remarkable distinction of having completed her matriculation with Ratan, Bhushan and Prabhakar degrees in Hindi. Her early marriage prevented her from pursuing her studies any further.

Shashi, the eldest of the Peshawaria sisters, was born on 31 December 1945. Parkash felt as if all his beliefs about women were now to be put to the test and he decided then and there that he would try to make his daughter all that he wished women to be. At the age of three, Shashi had learnt the English alphabet and could count fluently up to a hundred. When she was five years old he admitted her to the Sacred Heart Convent, run by an order of missionary nuns from Belgium. When Lala Muni Lal, Parkash Lal's father, learnt that his grand-daughter had been admitted to a Christian school and, that too, without his permission, he was furious. Parkash told his father that the latter had the right to interfere in the case of his own son, but certainly not in that of his son's daughter. For this impudence, and for being headstrong in not listening to his father, Parkash Lal was cut off from all allowances.

Knowing that he did not even have a graduate degree to his name, Parkash Lal was wondering what to do when his father-in-law offered him a substantial amount of money to start his own business. He opened a drapery store and soon had a flourishing business going. The 1948 war with Pakistan, however, put an end to this venture.

A year later, on the 9th day of June 1949, Prem Lata gave birth to another daughter who was named Kiran (ray). The third daughter, Reeta, came into this world within a year and a half and the (fourth) youngest, Anu, was born in 1960. With the birth of the youngest daughter also came the division of property in the Peshawaria family.

Kiran maintains that she inherited the genetic strain of academics and sports from her parents. The exigencies imposed by their respective families and early marriage into a traditional home had curtailed the ambitions of both her parents. Their starved passions found their way genetically into the daughters, and, with these standards as the foundation, they instilled in their daughters the thirst and quest for excellence in the field of sports and education.

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The Peshawaria sisters studied at the aforementioned Sacred Heart Convent at Amritsar. The school was located about 16 kilometres from their home and so a considerable amount of time was spent in travelling to and from school. This meant waking up very early and also spending extra